

RH02

Sources of Rajasthan History

One to two questions a paper on average - but RAS Pre 2024 alone took four or five straight from the author-to-work list. Literary works matched to their authors is the single most reliably repeated item in the whole of Rajasthan History.

This is the driest chapter in the syllabus and one of the easiest to score in. Nobody asks you to interpret a source. They ask who wrote what, which inscription sits in which district, which state issued which coin. It is a filing job, not a thinking job.

Sources of Rajasthan History

Inscriptions - ancient

- Barli - oldest
- Ghosundi / Hathibada
- Yupa pillars - Nandsa, Badva
- Bijaygarh - Bhim ki Lat
- Man Mori, Samoli

Inscriptions - medieval

- Harsha 973
- Atpur 977
- Rajor 960
- Bijolia 1170
- Delhi-Topra 1164
- Chirwa 1273

Prashastis

- Ranakpur 1439
- Kumbhalgarh 1460
- Raisingh 1594
- Raj Prashasti 1676 - largest in India

Coins

- Gadhiya - Indo-Sasanian
- Rupak, Dramma - Chauhan
- Jhadshahi - Jaipur
- Vijayshahi - Jodhpur
- Gajshahi - Bikaner

Archival records

- Hakikat Bahi
- Hukumat ri Bahi
- Kamthana Bahi
- Kharita Bahi
- Pattas, Parwanas, Sanads

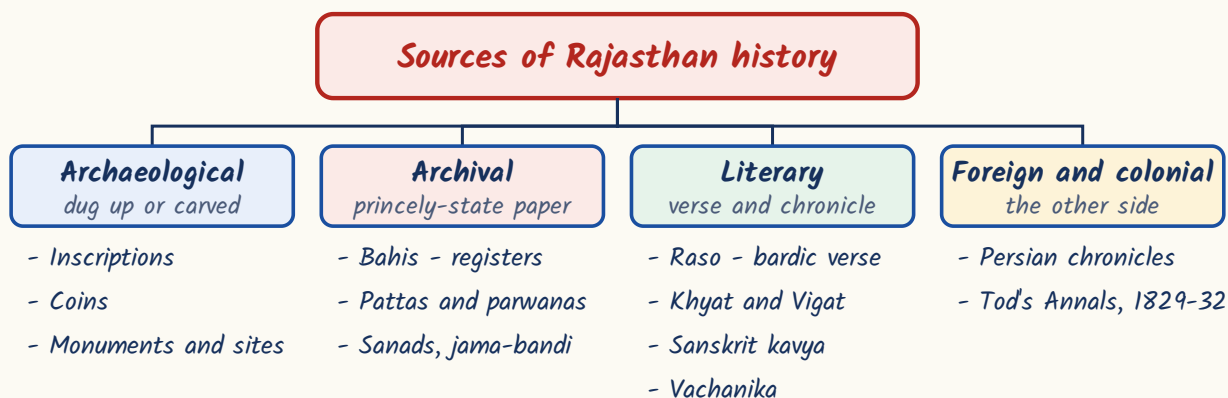
Literary & foreign

- Raso literature
- Khyat - Nainsi
- Sanskrit kavya
- Persian chronicles
- Col. James Tod

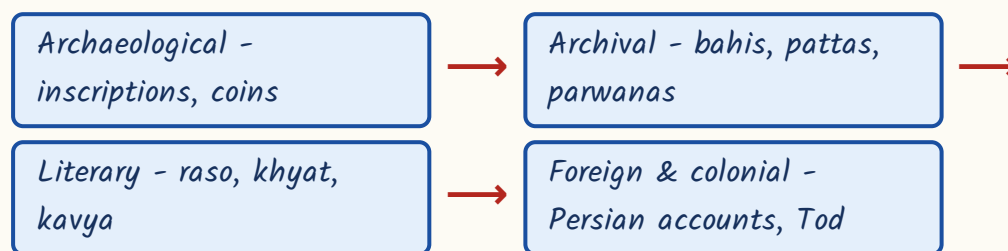
Three baskets - file every source before you memorise it

There are only three kinds of source, and every name in this chapter drops into one of them. Archaeological - things dug up or carved in stone and metal: inscriptions and coins. Archival - the paper record of the princely states: bahis, pattas, parwanas. Literary - what people wrote as literature or history: raso, khyat, vachanika, Persian chronicles, colonial and modern histories. Do the filing first. Then a question that looks unfamiliar still gets you a 50-50 guess.

File every name before you learn it



How a source question is built



- Inscriptions are the most reliable class - dated, contemporary, and hard to tamper with.
- Coins tell you political extent, titles and economy - which is why the state-to-coin list is asked.
- Bahis are administrative, not literary - they record what actually happened day to day.
- Khyats are bardic prose histories - useful, but partisan towards the patron house.
- Persian chronicles give the other side of every battle Rajasthan lost.

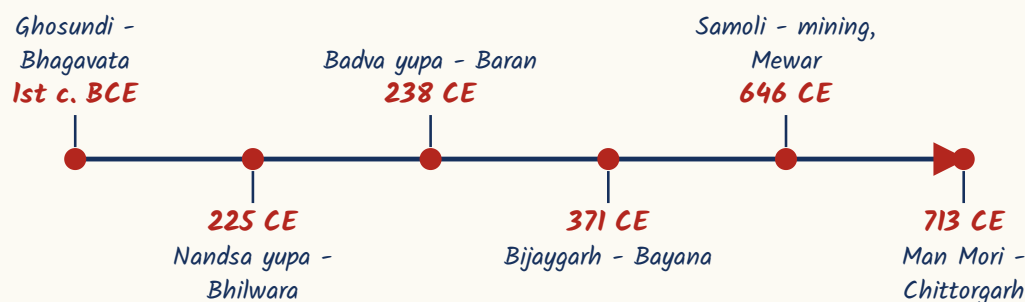
TRAP

Do not confuse a prashasti with a khyat. A prashasti is a praise-inscription on stone, contemporary and dated. A khyat is a prose chronicle written on paper, often long after the event. RPSC has framed options that mix the two categories.

Ancient inscriptions - Barli to the yupa pillars

Start with the oldest and work forward. The one fact everybody must know: the Barli inscription of Ajmer district is Rajasthan's oldest inscription. It is in Brahmi script, in Prakrit, and it refers to Lord Vira, that is Mahavira. G.H. Ojha brought it to light in 1912 and it is kept in the museum at Ajmer.

The ancient inscriptions in date order



The ancient set - place, date, what it tells you

Inscription	District	Date	What it establishes
Barli	Ajmer	Earliest in Rajasthan	Brahmi, Prakrit, refers to Lord Vira (Mahavira)
Ghosundi / Hathibada	Chittorgarh (near Nagari)	1st century BCE	Earliest evidence of Bhagavata worship of Sankarshana and Vasudeva; king Sarvatata's Ashvamedha
Nandsa yupa	Bhilwara	225 CE	Sacrificial pillar - Vedic yajna tradition
Badva yupa	Baran	238 CE	Sacrifice by three Maukhari brothers
Bijaygarh pillar (Bhim ki Lat)	Bayana	VS 428 = 371 CE	Varika ruler Vishnuvardhana's Pundarika yajna
Samoli	Udaipur	646 CE	Shiladitya - earliest evidence of mining in Mewar
Man Mori	Chittorgarh	713 CE	Maurya rulers of Chittor; found by Col. Tod, lost at sea
Mandore / Ghatiyala	Jodhpur	837 / 861 CE	Pratiharas of Mandore; Ghatiyala is of Kakkuka

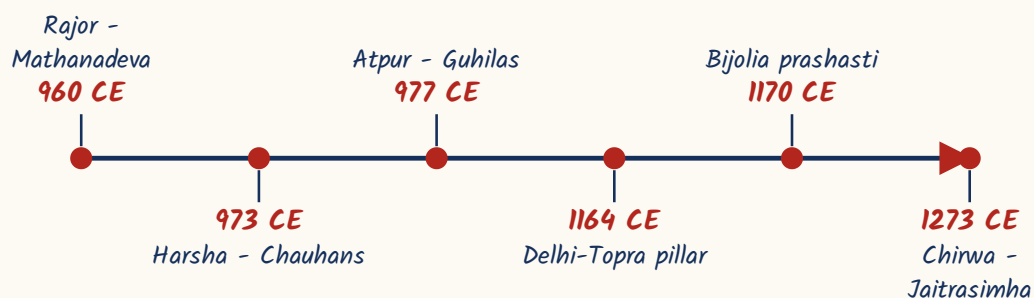
The yupa group - remember them as a set

- Yupa means a sacrificial post; these pillars record Vedic sacrifices, so they prove Brahmanical ritual in 3rd-century Rajasthan.
- Nandsa (Bhilwara) 225 CE - Barnala 227 CE - Badva (Baran) 238 CE - Bichpuria/Uniara (Tonk) 274 CE.
- Badva is the Maukhari one; three brothers performed the sacrifice.
- Nagda or Aparajita inscription, 661 CE, sits between Samoli and Man Mori in the Mewar sequence.
- The Man Mori inscription was carried off towards England and lost at sea - that romantic detail is itself asked.

Medieval inscriptions and the great prashastis

From the 10th century, inscriptions get longer and start giving full genealogies. That is what makes them the backbone of dynastic history. For each one, learn three things only - the year, the dynasty it belongs to, and the one claim it makes.

The medieval inscriptions in date order



The medieval set

Inscription	Year	Dynasty / ruler	The claim it makes
Rajor (Rajorgarh, Alwar)	960 CE	Mathanadeva, Pratihara feudatory	The only record that actually uses the term Gurjara-Pratihara

Inscription	Year	Dynasty / ruler	The claim it makes
Harsha (Harshnath), Sikar	973 CE	Chauhans of Shakambhari	Earliest surviving Chauhan record; genealogy plus the Shiva temple on Harshagiri
Atpur (Ahar), Udaipur	977 CE	Guhilas, Shaktikumar	Genealogy of the Guhilas from Guhadatta
Delhi-Shivalik (Delhi-Topra) pillar	1164 CE	Chauhan Vigraharaja IV	Conquest claimed from the Himalaya to the Vindhyas
Bijolia, Bhilwara	1170 CE	Someshvara's reign, Chauhans	Chauhans of Sambhar and Ajmer called Vatsa-gotra Brahmins; Ajayaraja founded Ajmer
Chirwa, Udaipur	1273 CE	Guhilas - Jaitrasimha, Tejasimha, Samarasimha	Composed by Ratnaprabha Suri
Ranakpur	1439 CE	Rana Kumbha's line	Traces Mewar from Bappa Rawal; Dharanashah built the Chaumukha Adinatha temple
Kumbhalgarh (five slabs)	1460 CE	Rana Kumbha	Composed by Kavi Mahesh
Raisingh Prashasti, Junagarh fort, Bikaner	1594 CE	Bikaner Rathores	Composed by the Jain sage Jaita
Raj Prashasti, Rajsamand	1676 CE	Maharana Raj Singh	25 black-stone slabs - the largest stone inscription in India

- Raj Prashasti was composed by Ranchhod Bhatt Tailang - and 25 slabs and largest in India are both asked.
- The Kirti Stambha Prashasti of Chittorgarh was written by Atri and his son Mahesh - the same Mahesh who did Kumbhalgarh.
- Bijolia gives you two separate facts for two separate chapters - Chauhan origin as Brahmins, and Ajayaraja as founder of Ajmer.
- Delhi-Topra 1164 and Bijolia 1170 sit six years apart - useful for an ordering question.

Coins - two layers, and only two

Coins in Rajasthan come in two layers. An ancient and early-medieval layer, and a princely-state layer of silver rupees named after the ruler who first struck them. The princely layer is where the marks are, because it is perfect matching material.

- Gadhiya coins - Indo-Sasanian type, circulated in western Rajasthan.
- Rupak and Dramma - the Chauhan-period coinage.
- Punch-marked Karshapanas - the oldest layer; 3,075 of them came out of Rairh in Tonk.
- Princely-state silver is named after a ruler - so the name itself tells you the state if you have learnt the list.

Coin to princely state - learn this as one block

Coin	State
Jhadshahi	Jaipur
Vijayshahi, Bhimshahi	Jodhpur
Gajshahi	Bikaner
Akhaishahi, Muhammadshahi	Jaisalmer
Swaroopshahi, Chandori	Mewar (Udaipur)
Gumanshahi	Kota
Ramshahi, Katarshahi	Bundi
Salimshahi	Pratapgarh

The archives - bahis, pattas and parwanas

Every princely state kept registers. A bahi is a register, and the whole body of them is called the Bahiyat. The examiner's whole interest is which bahi recorded what, so learn the four names below by their subject, not by their sound. All of this material is now in the Rajasthan State Archives at Bikaner - that is the standard one-liner answer to where are the records kept.

Bahi to subject

Record	What it contains
Hakikat Bahi	The daily routine of the ruler
Hukumat ri Bahi	Royal orders
Kamthana Bahi	Construction and building works
Kharita Bahi	Correspondence

- Pattas are grants of land or revenue; parwanas are orders; sanads are charters.
- Khatoot and jama-bandi papers of the former states complete the archival set.
- The Rajasthan State Archives, Bikaner is the principal repository of princely-state records.
- The museum at Ajmer, opened in 1908, holds the Barli inscription.

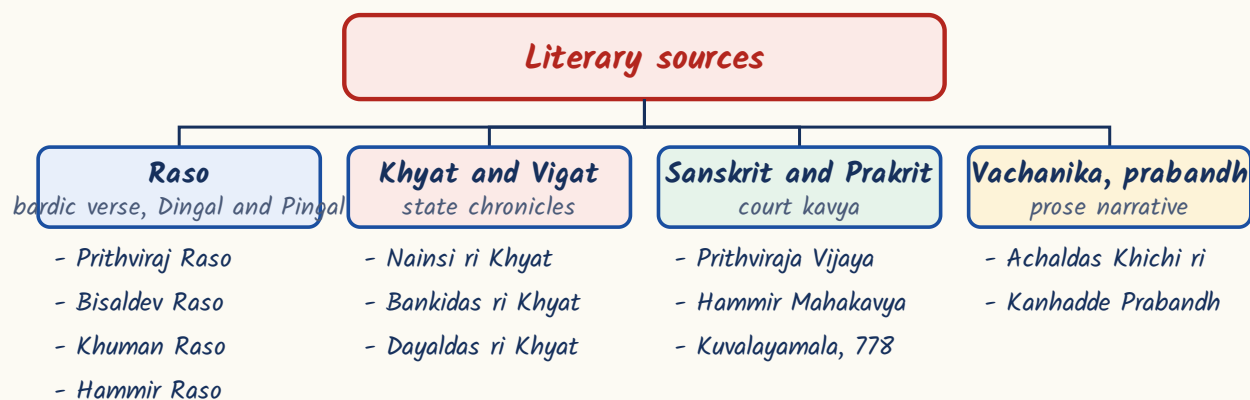
TRAP

Hukumat ri Bahi is royal orders, not land revenue settlement. That exact wrong pairing has been used as a NOT-correctly-matched option. Kamthana is construction - think karm, work.

Literary sources - the list that RPSC actually asks

This is the money section. Author-to-work matching has appeared in every recent paper and RAS Pre 2024 built four separate questions out of it. Do not read this section - drill it. Cover the right column and say the author. Then cover the left column and say the work.

Literary sources by genre



Raso literature - bardic verse in Dingal and Pingal

Raso works and their authors

Work	Author	Subject
Prithviraj Raso	Chand Bardai	Prithviraja III; written in Pingal
Bisaldev Raso	Narpati Nalha	Vigraharaja IV, that is Visaladeva
Khuman Raso	Dalpat Vijay	The Guhilas of Mewar
Hammir Raso	Sarangdhar	Hammir Dev of Ranthambore

Sanskrit, vachanika, khyat and the modern histories

Everything else, by author

Work	Author	Note
Hammir Mahakavya	Nayanchandra Suri	Sanskrit, on Hammir Dev of Ranthambore
Prithviraja Vijaya	Jayanaka	Sanskrit, on Prithviraja III

Work	Author	Note
Kuvalayamala	Uddyotana Suri	Prakrit, 778 CE, composed at Jalore (Jabalipura)
Achaldas Khichi ri Vachanika	Shivdas Gadan	Achaldas Khichi of Gagron vs Hoshang Shah of Malwa
Kanhadde Prabandh	Padmanabh, 1455	Kanhadadeva of Jalore vs Alauddin Khalji
Veli Krishan Rukmani Ri	Prithviraj Rathore	Dingal poetry
Nainsi ri Khyat, Marwar ra Pargana ri Vigat	Muhnnot Nainsi	Vigat is regarded as the first gazetteer of Rajasthan
Vansh Bhaskar	Suryamal Mishran	Dingal; largely on Bundi
Veer Vinod	Kaviraj Shyamaldas	The official history of Mewar
Rajputane ka Itihas	Gaurishankar Hirachand Ojha	The modern standard history

- Other khyats: Bankidas ri Khyat (Marwar), Dayaldas ri Khyat (Bikaner), Mundiya ri Khyat and Bhatia ri Khyat (Jaisalmer).
- Muhnnot Nainsi (1610-70) was Diwan of Maharaja Jaswant Singh I of Jodhpur.
- G.H. Ojha called Nainsi the Abul Fazl of Rajputana - a favourite one-liner.
- Kuvalayamala matters beyond history - it records the languages and society of 8th-century Rajasthan.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 - Hammir Mahakavya was composed by whom?

Answer: Nayanchandra Suri. Do not slip into Sarangdhar, who wrote Hammir Raso.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 - Kuvalayamala, composed in 778 CE at Jalore, is the work of? Answer: Uddyotana Suri.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 as a match question - Prithviraj Raso to Chand Bardai, Bisaldev Raso to Narpati Nalha, Khuman Raso to Dalpat Vijay, Hammir Raso to Sarangdhar. The same four have been recycled for years.

YAAD RAKHO

Two Hammir works, two different authors. Hammir Mahakavya = Nayanchandra Suri (Sanskrit, maha = the big Sanskrit one). Hammir Raso = Sarangdhar. And two Suris - Nayanchandra for Hammir, Uddyotana for Kuvalayamala.

Persian accounts, Colonel Tod, and the modern historians

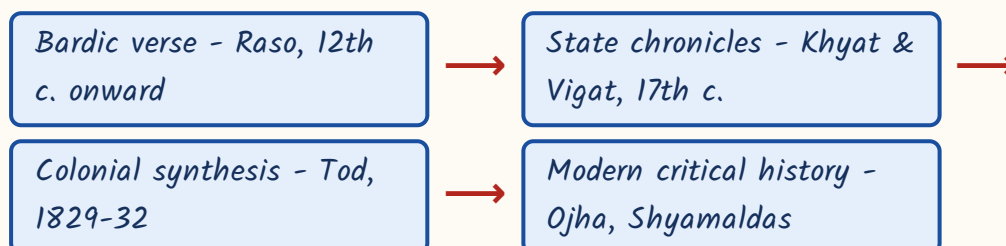
Rajasthan's own sources are court-centred and flattering. The Persian chronicles of Delhi and the Mughals give you the other side - dates of campaigns, the size of armies, what actually happened at a siege. Then in the 19th century a British political agent turned all of it into a single narrative, and modern Indian historians corrected him.

- *Tabaqat-i-Nasiri* - Minhaj-us-Siraj.
- *Tarikh-i-Firozshahi* - Ziauddin Barani.
- *Akbarnama* and *Ain-i-Akbari* - Abul Fazl.
- *Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri* - Jahangir himself.
- *Padshahnama* - Abdul Hamid Lahori.
- Col. James Tod was Political Agent to the Western Rajput States from 1818; his guru was the Jain yati Gyanchandra.
- *Annals and Antiquities of Rajasthan*, London, 1829-32; *Travels in Western India* appeared posthumously.
- Tod is called the father of Rajasthan's history and was known locally as Ghode wale Baba.

Nainsi vs Tod - the two men who built the record

Muhnnot Nainsi (1610-70)	Col. James Tod (from 1818)
Diwan of Jaswant Singh I of Jodhpur	British Political Agent, Western Rajput States
Nainsi ri Khyat; Marwar ra Pargana ri Vigat	<i>Annals and Antiquities of Rajasthan</i> (1829-32)
Wrote in Rajasthani, from state records	Wrote in English, from bardic tradition and his yati guru
Called the Abul Fazl of Rajputana	Called the father of Rajasthan's history; Ghode wale Baba

How Rajasthan's history got written - the four stages



ASKED IN RAS

Repeatedly asked in one form or another - who is called the father of the history of Rajasthan? Answer: Colonel James Tod. And who is the Abul Fazl of Rajputana? Answer: Muhnot Nainsi. RPSC likes putting both names in the same option set.

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - the Rajasthan State Archives at Bikaner remains the state's principal repository of princely-state records, and the Government Museum at Ajmer, opened in 1908 in Akbar's Daulat Khana, still holds the Barli inscription. Whenever a Rajasthan museum or archive item appears in current affairs, it is usually one of these two; the static answer to where it kept has not changed.

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - alongside the Bikaner archives, the Rajasthan Oriental Research Institute at Jodhpur remains the state's principal manuscript repository, and its collections are the ones that appear whenever manuscript conservation or digitisation is in the news. The exam answer stays split three ways: princely-state records at the Rajasthan State Archives, Bikaner; manuscripts at the Rajasthan Oriental Research Institute, Jodhpur; the Barli inscription at the Government Museum, Ajmer.

REVISION RECAP

1. Barli (Ajmer) - Rajasthan's oldest inscription; Brahmi, Prakrit, refers to Lord Vira; G.H. Ojha, 1912.
2. Ghosundi / Hathibada (Chittorgarh) - earliest Bhagavata worship of Sankarshana and Vasudeva; king Sarvatata.
3. Yupa pillars: Nandsa 225, Barnala 227, Badva 238 (three Maukhari brothers), Bichpuria 274 CE.

4. Bijaygarh Bayana - Bhim ki Lat - VS 428 = 371 CE, Varika Vishnuvardhana's Pundarika yajna.
5. Samoli 646 CE - earliest mining evidence in Mewar; Man Mori 713 CE - found by Tod, lost at sea.
6. Rajor 960 CE - the only inscription that uses the term Gurjara-Pratihara; Mathanadeva.
7. Harsha 973 CE (Sikar) - earliest Chauhan record; Atpur 977 CE - Guhila genealogy from Guhadatta.
8. Delhi-Topra 1164 - Vigraharaja IV; Bijolia 1170 - Chauhans as Vatsa-gotra Brahmins, Ajayaraja founded Ajmer.
9. Chirwa 1273 - Guhilas, by Ratnaprabha Suri; Ranakpur 1439 - Mewar from Bappa Rawal, Dharanashah.
10. Kumbhalgarh 1460 - Kavi Mahesh; Kirti Stambha Prashasti - Atri and his son Mahesh.
11. Raisingh Prashasti 1594 - Junagarh fort, Bikaner, by the Jain sage Jaita.
12. Raj Prashasti 1676 - Rajsamand, 25 black slabs, Ranchhod Bhatt Tailang, largest stone inscription in India.
13. Coins: Gadhiya - Indo-Sasanian west; Rupak and Dramma - Chauhan; 3,075 punch-marked coins at Rairh.
14. Jhadshahi-Jaipur, Vijayshahi-Jodhpur, Gajshahi-Bikaner, Akhaishahi-Jaisalmer, Swaroopshahi-Mewar, Gumanshahi-Kota.
15. Bahis: Hakikat - ruler's daily routine; Hukumat - orders; Kamthana - construction; Kharita - correspondence.
16. Rajasthan State Archives = Bikaner. Barli inscription = Ajmer museum, 1908.
17. Raso quartet: Prithviraj-Chand Bardai, Bisaldev-Narpati Nalha, Khuman-Dalpat Vijay, Hammir-Sarangdhar.
18. Nainsi - Diwan of Jaswant Singh I; Vigat = first gazetteer of Rajasthan; Abul Fazl of Rajputana.
19. Tod - Political Agent from 1818, Annals and Antiquities 1829-32, father of Rajasthan's history, Ghode wale Baba.